

Working on the Marvel Cinematic Universe is a true gift. Of course there is the obvious—getting to spend every day drawing and working on characters and stories that I love—but the gift Marvel has to offer lies deeper than that.

Most projects in the film industry consist of a four-month gig, and then an artist like me has to find work somewhere else. At Marvel, however, I've been allowed the chance to truly invest in characters across multiple films, and watch them grow and change in ways that could never happen in a single film. In Cap's case, we've seen him sacrifice himself for his country only to wake 70 years later to find that he no longer recognizes much of what he "died" for. Since my job consists of developing designs for characters that achieve the needs of the story and accomplish the director's vision, I've worked on making Cap's journey visual. It's a dream come true to design a character's costume in two periods separated by 70 years and an emotional journey that's even further distancing.

That's what is so amazing about the MCU. It is constantly redefining and refining its characters in such profound ways that it requires solid design directions in order for the costumes and moments to reflect the character's journey. The touchstones of design for Cap started with nostalgic innocence coupled with super-soldier, and have developed into not only a super hero, but also a real leader. Within the pages of this book, you have gotten a taste of the next stage of Cap's adventure.

Furthermore, the Russo brothers' reinvention of Captain America for The Winter Soldier was an extraordinary journey to be a part of. They had a distinct vision of where they wanted to take the character, so the designs of each of Cap's costumes were exercises in joy for me. They wanted to take the super-soldier costume from the comics and turn it into a stealth costume, representing Steve's willingness to do black-ops missions. They were looking to show him becoming part of the complicated modern world of espionage and not enjoying it.

For me, returning to the nostalgia of WWII for the Smithsonian exhibition was honestly one of my favorite projects I've ever done for Marvel. Not only did I get to paint two huge murals, but they were also used with such precision in the story that it makes the hard work doubly rewarding.

I hope the touchstones of design laid out by the Russos are evident on every page of this book, as they are evident in every second of the film.

Thank you, Kevin, Joe, and Anthony, for adding yet another brilliant chapter to Cap's journey within the Marvel Cinematic Universe.



Ryan Meinerding